

Chapter [Five]

*On indicating the existent, the thing, and their first division,
wherewith attention is directed to the objective [sought]*

(1) We say: The ideas¹ of “the existent,” “the thing,” and “the necessary” are impressed in the soul in a primary way. This impression does
 20 not require better known things to bring it about. [This is similar]² to what obtains in the category of assent,³ where there are primary principles, found to be true in themselves, causing [in turn] assent to the truths of other [propositions]. If the expression denoting them does not occur to the
 25 mind or is not understood, then it would be impossible to know whatever is known through them. [This is so] even though the informative act striving to bring them to mind or to explain what expressions indicate them is not engaged in an endeavor to impart knowledge not [already]
 30 present in the natural intelligence, but is merely drawing attention to explaining what the speaker intends and upholds. This may occur through things which, in themselves, are less evident than the things intended to be made known but which, for some cause or some expression, have become better known.

(2) Similarly, in conceptual matters, there are things which are principles for conception that are conceived in themselves. If one desires to indicate them, [such indication] would not, in reality, constitute making an unknown thing known but would merely consist in drawing attention to them or bringing them to mind through the use of a name or a sign which, in itself, may be less known than [the principles] but which, for some cause or circumstance, happens to be more obvious in its signification.

(3) If, then, such a sign is used, the soul is awakened [to the fact] that such a meaning is being brought to mind, in [the sense] that it is the intended [meaning and] not another, without the sign in reality having given [any] knowledge of it.

(4) If every conception were to require that [another] conception should precede it, then [such a] state of affairs would lead either to an infinite regress or to circularity.

(5) The things that have the highest claim to be conceived in themselves are those common to all matters—as, for example, “the existent,” “the one thing,” and others. For this reason, none of these things can be shown by a proof totally devoid of circularity or by the exposition of better known things. Hence, whoever attempts to place in them something as a [defining] constituent falters—as, for example, one who says: “It is of the existent’s true nature to be either active or acted on.” This, while inescapably the case, belongs to the division of the existent, the existent being better known than the active and the passive. The masses conceive the reality of the existent without knowing at all that it must be either active or passive. For my part, up to this point, this has not been evident to me except through a syllogism—nothing else. How, then, would it be the state of one who strives to define the state of the evident thing in terms of some quality belonging to it which requires a proof to establish that it exists for [that thing]?

(6) The case is similar with somebody’s statement: “The thing is that about which it is valid [to give] an informative statement,”⁴ for “is valid” is less known than “the thing”; and “informative statement” is [likewise] less known than “the thing.” How, then, can this be the definition of the thing? Indeed, “is valid” and “information” are known only after one uses, in explaining what they are, [terms] indicating that each is either a “thing,” a “matter,” a “whatever,” or a “that which [is]”—all of these being like synonyms of the word “thing.”

(7) How, then, can the thing be truly defined in terms of what is known only through it? Yes, in this and similar things there may be some act of directing attention; but, in reality, if you say, "The thing is that about which it is valid [to give] an informative statement," it is as if you have said, "The thing is the thing about which it is valid [to give] an informative statement," because the meaning of "whatever," "that which," and "the thing" is one and the same. You would have then included "the thing" in the definition of "the thing." Still, we do not deny that through this [statement] and its like, despite its vitiating starting point, there occurs in some manner a directing of attention to the thing.

(8) [Moreover] we say: The meaning of "existence" and the meaning of "thing" are conceived in the soul and are two meanings,⁵ whereas "the existent," "the established," and "the realized" are synonyms. We do not doubt that their meaning has been realized in the soul of whoever is reading this book.

(9) "The thing," or its equivalent, may be used in all languages to indicate some other meaning. For, to everything there is a reality by virtue of which it is what it is. Thus, the triangle has a reality in that it is a triangle, and whiteness has reality in that it is whiteness. It is that which we should perhaps call "proper existence," not intending by this the meaning given to affirmative existence; for the expression "existence" is also used to denote many meanings, one of which is the reality a thing happens to have. Thus, [the reality] a thing happens to have is, as it were, its proper existence.⁶

(10) To resume, we say: It is evident that each thing has a reality proper to it—namely, its quiddity. It is known that the reality proper to each thing is something other than the existence that corresponds to what is affirmed.

(11) This is because, if you said, "The reality of such a thing exists either in concrete things,⁷ or in the soul, or absolutely, being common to both," this would have a meaning [that was] realized and understood; [whereas,] if you were to say, "The reality of such a thing is the reality of such a thing," or "The reality of such a thing is a reality," this would be superfluous, useless talk. [Again,] if you were to say, "The reality of such a thing is a thing," this, too, would not be a statement imparting knowledge of what is not known. Even less useful than this is for you to say,

“Reality is a thing,” unless by “thing” you mean “the existent”; for then it is as though you have said, “The reality of such a thing is an existing reality.” If, however, you said, “The reality of A is something and the reality of B is another thing,” this would be sound, imparting knowledge; because [in saying this] you make the reservation within yourself that [the former] is something specific, differing from that other [latter] thing. This would be as if you said, “[This is] the reality of A, and the reality of B is another reality.” If it were not for both this reservation [you make within yourself] and this conjunction, [the statement] would not impart knowledge. This, then, is the meaning intended by “the thing.” The necessary concomitance of the meaning of existence never separates from it at all; rather, the meaning of existence is permanently concomitant with it because the thing exists either in the concrete or in the estimative [faculty] and the intellect. If [this] were not the case, it would not be a thing.

(12) Concerning what is said—[namely,] “The thing is that about which information is given”—[this] is true.⁸ But when, in addition to this, it is said, “The thing may be absolutely nonexistent,” this is a matter that must be looked into. If by the nonexistent is meant the nonexistent in external reality, this would be possible; for it is possible for a thing that does not exist in external things to exist in the mind. But if [something] other than this is meant, this would be false and there would be no information about it at all. It would not be known except only as [something] conceived in the soul. [To the notion] that [the nonexistent] would be conceived in the soul as a concept that refers to some external thing, [we say] “Certainly not!”

(13) Regarding the informative statement, [the above analysis is correct] because information is always about something realized in the mind. No affirmative information about the absolutely nonexistent is [ever] given. If, moreover, information about it is given in the negative, then an existence in some respect is given it in the mind. [This is] because our saying “it” entails a reference, and reference to the nonexistent that has no concept in any respect at all in the mind is impossible. For how can anything affirmative be said about the nonexistent when the meaning of our statement, “The nonexistent is such,” is that the description “such” is realized for the nonexistent, there being no difference between the realized and the existent? It would be as though we have said, “This description exists for the nonexistent.” Indeed, we say:

(14) That which describes the nonexistent and is predicated of it either exists for the nonexistent and is realized for it or does not exist and is not realized for it. If it exists and is realized for the nonexistent, then it must, in itself, be either existent or nonexistent. If it is existent, then the
 5 nonexistent would have an existing description. But, if the description exists, then that which is described by it necessarily exists. The nonexistent would, then, be an existent—and this is impossible. If [however] the description is nonexistent, then how can that which in itself is nonexistent
 10 exist for something? For that which in itself does not exist cannot exist for the thing. Yes, the thing may exist in itself without existing for some other thing, [but this is a different matter].

(15) If, however, the description did not exist for the nonexistent, this would be [tantamount] to the denial of the description for the nonexistent; for, if it were not the denial of the description of the nonexistent, then, if
 15 we were to deny this description, we would obtain the opposite of this. Hence, there would be the existence of the description for it. And all this is false.

(16) We say only that we have knowledge of the nonexistent, because when the meaning occurs only in the soul and no reference to [what is]
 20 external [to the soul] is made by it, then what is known would be only that very thing in the soul. The assent, occurring in terms of the two parts of what is conceived, consists in [affirming] that it is possible that, in the nature of the thing known, an intellectually apprehended relation to what is external should occur (there being no [such] relation, however,
 25 at the present time). Nothing other than this is known.

(17) According to those who uphold the view [rejected above], there are matters in the assemblage of whatever is being informed about and known that, in [the state of] nonexistence, have no “thingness.”⁹ Whoever desires acquaintance with their doctrine should go to what they rave about in
 30 their statements—[statements] that hardly deserve preoccupation.

(18) These [people] have fallen into [the error] that they have because of their ignorance [of the fact] that giving information is about ideas that have an existence in the soul—even if these are nonexistent in external things—where the meaning of giving information about [these ideas] is

that they have some relation to external things. Thus, for example, if you said, "The resurrection will be," you would have understood "resurrection" and would have understood "will be." You would have predicated "will be," which is in the soul, of "resurrection," which is in the soul, in [the sense] that it would be correct for this meaning, with respect to another meaning also intellectually apprehended (namely, one intellectually apprehended in a future time), to be characterized by a third meaning (namely, [the object] of intellectual apprehension: existence). This [pattern of reasoning] applies correspondingly to matters relating to the past.¹⁰ It is thus clear that that about which information is given must have some sort of existence in the soul. Information, in truth, is about what exists in the soul and [only] accidentally about what exists externally.

(19) Hence, you have now understood the way in which "the thing" differs from what is understood by "the existent" and "the realized" and that, despite this difference, the two [that is, "the thing" and "the existent"] are necessary concomitants.

(20) Yet, it has reached me that some people say that what is realized is realized without being an existent, that the description of a thing can be something neither existing nor nonexisting¹¹ and that the [expressions] "that which" and "whichever" denote something other than that which [the expression] "the thing" denotes. Such people are not among the assemblage of the discerning; if challenged to distinguish between these expressions in terms of their meaning, they would be exposed.

(21) We now say: Although the existent, as you have known, is not a genus and is not predicated equally of what is beneath it, yet it has a meaning agreed on with respect to priority and posteriority. The first thing to which it belongs is the quiddity, which is substance, and then to what comes after it. Since it [has] one meaning, in the manner to which we have alluded, accidental matters adhere to it that are proper to it, as we have shown earlier. For this reason, it is taken care of by one science in the same way that anything pertaining to health has one science.

(22) It may also prove difficult for us to make known the state of the necessary, the possible, and the impossible through ascertained definition, [and we would have to make this known] only through a sign. All that has been said of the [things] that have reached you from the Ancients in defining this would almost entail circularity. This is because—as you

have come across in the [various] parts of the *Logic*—whenever they want to define the possible, they include in the definition either the necessary or the impossible, there being no other way save this. And when they want to define the necessary, they include in the definition either the possible or the impossible. [Similarly,] when they want to define the impossible, they include in its definition either the necessary or the possible. Thus, for example, if they define the possible, they would at one time say that it is that which is not necessary, or [at another] that it is the presently nonexistent whose existence at any supposed moment in the future is not impossible. [Again,] if they find that there is a need to define the necessary, they would say that it is either that which is not possible to suppose as nonexistent or that which is impossible to suppose [as anything] other than it is. Thus, at one time they include the possible in its definition and at another the impossible. And as regards the possible, they would already have included in its definition either the necessary or the impossible. Then [again,] when they wish to define the impossible, they either include the necessary in its definition by saying, “The impossible is that whose nonexistence is necessary,” or [they include] the possible by saying, “It is that for which it is not possible to exist,” or some other expression equivalent to these two.

(23) The case is similar with such statements as: “The impossible is that whose existence is not possible, or that whose nonexistence is necessary; the necessary is that whose nonexistence is not allowable and is impossible, or that for which it is not possible not to be; the possible is that for which it is not impossible to be or not to be, or that for which it is not necessary to be or not to be.” All this, as you see, is clearly circular. A fuller exposure of this is something you have come across in the *Analytics*.¹²

(24) Nonetheless, of these three, the one with the highest claim to be first conceived is the necessary. This is because the necessary points to the assuredness of existence, existence being better known than nonexistence. [This is] because existence is known in itself, whereas nonexistence is, in some respect or another, known through existence.

(25) From our explaining these matters, it will become clear to you that it is false for someone to say: “The nonexistent can be brought back into existence because it is the first thing about which information is

given in terms of existence. This is because, if the nonexistent were to be brought back into existence, then there would necessarily be a difference between it and that which is similar to it, if [that which is similar to] it were to exist in its place. If [only] similar, it would not be identical with it, because it is not the thing that had ceased to exist (this latter, in its state of nonexistence, being other than [the former]).”

(26) [But if one argues in this way,] the nonexistent becomes an existent in the manner to which we have alluded previously.¹³ Moreover, if the nonexistent were to be brought back into existence, then this would require that all of its special properties—in terms of which it is what it is—should be brought back into existence. But among these properties is the time [in which it existed]. But, if this time is brought back, then the thing would not have been brought back into existence, because that which would have been brought into existence is that which exists at another time. If [then] it is allowed that the nonexistent could return into existence with all the nonexistent properties previously existing with it, time [being considered] either as having real existence that has ceased to be or (according to what is known of their doctrines) as one of the accidents having correspondence with an existent,¹⁴ then we would be allowing that time and temporal [states] could return into existence. But then there would not be [one period] of time and [then] another and, hence, no return [of the nonexistent to existence].

(27) The mind, however, rejects [all] this in a manner that renders exposition unnecessary; all that is said concerning this is deviation from the path of [peripatetic] teaching.

Chapter [Six]

On commencing a discourse on the Necessary Existent and the possible existent; that the Necessary Existent has no cause; that the possible existent is caused; that the Necessary Existent has no equivalent in existence and is not dependent [in existence] on another

(1) We will now return to what we were [discussing] and say: There are specific properties that belong individually each to the Necessary Existent and the possible existent. We thus say: The things that enter existence

bear a [possible] twofold division in the mind. Among them there will be that which, when considered in itself, its existence would be not necessary. It is [moreover] clear that its existence would also not be impossible, since otherwise it would not enter existence. This thing is within the bound of possibility. There will also be among them that which, when considered in itself, its existence would be necessary.

(2) We thus say: That which in itself is a necessary existent has no cause, while that which in itself is a possible existent has a cause. Whatever is a necessary existent in itself is a necessary existent in all its aspects. The existence of the Necessary Existent cannot be equivalent to the existence of another where each would equal the other as regards necessary existence, becoming [thereby] necessary concomitants. The existence of the Necessary Existent cannot at all be a composite, [deriving] from multiplicity. The true nature of the Necessary Existent can in no manner be shared by another. From our verifying [all] this, it follows necessarily that the Necessary Existent is not [dependent on] relation, is neither changing nor multiple, and has nothing associated with His existence that is proper to Himself.

(3) That the Necessary Existent has no cause is obvious. For if in His existence the Necessary Existent were to have a cause, His existence would be by [that cause]. But whatever exists by something [else], if considered in itself, apart from another, existence for it would not be necessary. And every[thing] for which existence is not [found to be] necessary—if [the thing is] considered in itself, apart from another—is not a necessary existent in itself. It is thus evident that if what is in itself a necessary existent were to have a cause, it would not be in itself a necessary existent. Thus, it becomes clear that the Necessary Existent has no cause. From this it is [also] clear that it is impossible for a thing to be [both] a necessary existent in itself and a necessary existent though another. [This is] because, if its existence is rendered necessary through another, it cannot exist without the other. But [if anything] whatsoever cannot exist without another, its existence [as] necessary in itself is impossible. For if it were necessary in itself, then it would have to come into existence, there being no influence on its existence by way of necessity from that which is other and which affects the existence of something else. [But since such an influence has been supposed,] its existence would not be necessary in itself.

(4) Moreover, whatever is possible in existence when considered in itself, its existence and nonexistence are both due to a cause. [This is] because, if it comes into existence, then existence, as distinct from nonexistence, would have occurred to it. [Similarly,] if it ceases to exist,
 5 then nonexistence, as distinct from existence, would have occurred to it. Hence, in each of the two cases, what occurs to the thing must either occur through another or not. If [it occurs] through another, then [this] other is the cause. And if it did not exist through another, [then the nonexistence of the other is the cause of its nonexistence].

(5) Hence, it is clear that whatever exists after nonexistence has been specified with something possible other than itself. The case is the same with nonexistence. This is because the thing's quiddity is either sufficient for this specification or not. If its quiddity is sufficient for either of the two states of affairs [existence or nonexistence] to obtain, then
 10 that thing would be in itself of a necessary quiddity, when [the thing] has been supposed not to be necessary [in itself]. And this is contradictory. If [on the other hand] the existence of its quiddity is not sufficient [for specifying the possible with existence]—[the latter] being, rather, something whose existence is added to it—then its existence would be necessarily due to some other thing. [This,] then, would be its cause. Hence, it has a cause. In sum, then, either of the two things [existence or nonexistence] would obtain necessarily for [the possible that was] due, not to itself, but to a cause. The existential idea would be realized through a cause (namely, an existential cause); and the nonexistential idea [would be realized]
 20 through a cause (namely, the absence of the [former] existential idea, as you have known).

(6) We thus say: [The possible in itself] must become necessary through a cause and with respect to it. For, if it were not necessary, then with the existence of the cause and with respect to it, it would [still] be possible. It would then be possible for it to exist or not to exist, being specified with neither of the two states. [Once again,] from the beginning this would be in need of the existence of a third thing through which either existence (as distinct from nonexistence) or nonexistence (as distinct from existence) would be assigned for [the possible] when the cause of its
 30 existence with [this state of affairs] would not have been specified.¹ This would be another cause, and the discussion would extend to an infinite regress. And, if it regresses infinitely, the existence of the possible, with all this, would not have been specified by it. As such, its existence would not have been realized. This is impossible, not only because this leads to

an infinity of causes—for this is a dimension,² the impossibility of which is still open to doubt in this place—but because no dimension has been arrived at through which its existence is specified, when it has been supposed to be existing. Hence, it has been shown to be true that whatever is possible in its existence does not exist unless rendered necessary with respect to its cause.

[...]

Chapter [Four]

*On the primary attributes of the principle
that is necessary in its existence*

(1) There has now been established for you something whose existence is necessary. It has [also] been established for you that the Necessary Existent is one. Hence, the Necessary Existent is one, nothing sharing with Him in His rank, and thus nothing other than Him is a necessary existent. Since nothing other than Him is a necessary existent, He is the principle of the necessitation of the existence of everything, necessitating [each thing] either in a primary manner or through an intermediary. If the existence of everything other than Him derives from His existence, He is [the] First. We do not mean by "the First" an idea that is added to the necessity of His existence so that, by it, the necessity of His existence becomes multiple, but by it we mean a consideration of His relation to [what is] other [than Him].

(2) Know, moreover, that, if we have said—indeed, demonstrated—that the Necessary Existent does not become multiple in any respect whatsoever and that His essence is utterly unitary, pure truth, we do not mean by this that [certain] existences are also not negated of Him and that relation to existences does not occur to Him, for this would be impossible. This is because, in the case of every existent, certain modes of existence, varied and multiple, are negated of it. And every existent has a species of relation and reference toward [the other] existents.¹ [This is] particularly [true of] the existent from whom all existence emanates. But [what] we mean by our statement that He is one in essence and does not become multiple is that He is as such in His essence. If, thereafter, many positive and negative relations become attendant on Him, these are necessary concomitants of the essence that are caused by the essence; they exist after the existence of the essence, do not render the essence subsistent, and are not parts of it. Should someone say,

“If these are caused, then they would possess another relation [and so on,] and this would regress to infinity,” we would obligate him to reflect on what we have ascertained concerning the category of relation in this [metaphysical] discipline, where we strove to show that relation is finite.²
 5 In this is the resolution of his doubt.

(3) We now return [to our discussion] and say: The First has no quiddity other than His individual existence.³ You have known the meaning of quiddity and the things by which it differs from individual existence at the beginning of this our exposition.⁴ We say: It would not be true [to
 10 maintain] that the Necessary Existent has a quiddity of which necessary existence adheres as a necessary concomitant. Indeed, we will start from the beginning and say:

(4) The Necessary Existent⁵ may be intellectually apprehended as the very necessary existent itself, just as the one may be intellectually
 15 apprehended as the very one itself. From this, one may intellectually apprehend that the quiddity [of the Necessary Existent] is, for example, a human or some other substance, when that [same] human is [also] a necessary existent,⁶ just as one may intellectually apprehend of the one that it is water, air, or human, [each] being one.

(5) You may reflect and know this from the controversy over [the question] of whether the principle in the natural sciences is one or many. For some have made the principle one, some many.

(6) Among those who made it one, some made the first principle not the essence of one, but something [else] which is one—for example, water, air, fire, or some other thing. Some [on the other hand] have made the
 25 principle the essence of one inasmuch as it is one, not something to which the one has accidentally occurred. Hence, there is a difference between a quiddity in which the one and the existent occur accidentally and between the one and the existent inasmuch as it is one and an existent.

(7) Hence, we say: The Necessary Existent cannot be of a characterization that entails composition so that there would be some quiddity (that quiddity being necessary in [its] existence) such that that quiddity would have a meaning other than its reality (that meaning being necessary existence). For example, if that quiddity consists in the fact of being
 30

a human, then the fact of being a human would be other than the fact of being a necessary existent. For then there would either be a reality for our saying “necessary existence,” or there would not. It is impossible for this meaning not to have a reality when it is the principle of every reality; indeed, it confirms [every other] reality and validates it.

(8) If [this meaning] has a reality which is other than that quiddity, then—if it is necessary for that necessity, with respect to existence, to be connected with that quiddity and [if the necessity] would not be necessary without it—the meaning of the Necessary Existent inasmuch as it is the Necessary Existent would come to be through something which is not itself. Hence, it would not be the Necessary Existent inasmuch as it is the Necessary Existent. And, viewed in terms of itself inasmuch as it is a necessary existent, it would not be a necessary existent because it has something through which it is rendered necessary.

This is impossible if it is taken absolutely, unrestricted by pure existence that attaches to quiddity. If taken as attaching to the quiddity, then, even if it is connected with that thing, that quiddity is not at all absolutely necessary in existence; nor does the necessity of existence occur to it absolutely, because it is not necessary at all times, whereas the absolutely necessary in existence is necessary at all times. This is not the state of existence if taken absolutely, not restricted by the pure necessity that attaches to quiddity. Hence, there would be no harm if one were to say that, in this respect, that existence is caused by the quiddity or by some other thing.

(9) This is because it is possible for existence to be caused, whereas absolute necessity that is essential is not caused. It thus remains that the absolutely necessary existent in essence, realized inasmuch as it is a necessary existent in itself, is a necessary existent without that quiddity. Therefore, that quiddity would occur accidentally—if this were possible—to the Necessary Existent that realizes its existence in itself. The Necessary Existent is, hence, indicated in itself by the mind. And the Necessary Existent is realized even if that occurring quiddity did not exist. Hence, that quiddity would not be a quiddity of that thing indicated by the mind as being a necessary existent, but [it] would be the quiddity of

something that attaches to it. [But] it had been postulated as the quiddity of that thing and not another. This is a contradiction. Hence, there is no quiddity for the Necessary Existent other than its being the Necessary Existent. And this is [the thing's] "thatness," [its individual existence].

(10) We say: If individual existence and existence were to occur to quiddity, then they would become necessary concomitants of it either due to itself or due to something extraneous. It is impossible [for this] to be due to the quiddity itself. For, that which follows [another] follows only an existing thing. Hence, it follows necessarily that the quiddity would have an existence prior to its existence, and this is impossible.

(11) We thus say: Everything that has a quiddity other than [individual] existence is caused. This is because you have known that, with regard to the quiddity which is extraneous to individual existence, existence and individual existence do not take the place of the thing that renders [another] subsistent. [Individual existence] would, then, have to be a concomitant.

(12) Hence, either it would be a necessary concomitant of the quiddity because it is that quiddity, or it would be its necessary concomitant because of something [else]. [Now,] the meaning of our saying "necessary concomitance" is to be a follower of existence. Nothing follows an existent except an existent. If, then, individual existence follows quiddity and is in itself a necessary concomitant of it, then, in its existence, individual existence would have followed an existence. And, [in the case] of everything that in its existence follows an existence, that which it follows exists essentially prior to it. The quiddity, hence, would have existed in itself prior to its existence—and this is contradictory. It remains that the existence it has is due to a cause. Hence, everything that has a quiddity is caused. The rest of the things, other than the Necessary Existent, have quiddities. And it is these quiddities that in themselves are possible in existence, existence occurring to them externally.

(13) The First, hence, has no quiddity. Those things possessing quiddities have existence emanate on them from Him. He is pure existence with the condition of negating privation and all other description of Him. Moreover, the rest of the things possessing quiddities are possible, coming into existence through Him. The meaning of my statement, "He is pure existence with the condition of negating all other additional [attributes] of Him," is not that this is the absolute existence in which there is

participation [by others]. If there is an existent with this description, it would not be the pure existent with the condition of negation, but the existent without the condition of positive affirmation.⁷ I mean, regarding the First, that He is the existent with the condition that there is no additional composition, whereas this other is the existent without the condition of [this] addition.⁸ For this reason, the universal is predicated of all things, whereas [pure existence] is not predicated of anything that has addition.⁹ Everything other than Him has addition.

(14) The First also has no genus. This is because the First has no quiddity. That which has no quiddity has no genus, since genus is spoken of in answer to the question, “What is it?” and [moreover] genus in one respect is a part of a thing; and it has been ascertained that the First is not a composite.

(15) Furthermore, the idea of genus is either [the same as] the Necessary Existent, in which case it would not depend on there being a differentia, [or it is not]. If it is not the Necessary Existent and renders the Necessary Existent subsistent, then the Necessary Existent would be rendered subsistent by that which is not a necessary existent—and this is contradictory. The First, then, has no genus.

(16) For this reason, the First has no differentia. Since He has neither genus nor differentia, He has no definition. There is no demonstration of Him, since there is no cause of Him.¹⁰ For this reason there is no “why” regarding Him, and you shall know that there is no “why-ness” for His act.¹¹

[...]